An Artist Who Turns Pumpkins into Spooky Faces

From: DOGOnews Mined: 2026-10-22 3 min read

Ray Villafane does not just **carve** pumpkins. He turns them into amazing **3-D sculptures** with spooky faces.

Villafane grew up in New York. He became an art teacher in Michigan. One Halloween, he **carved** a pumpkin so cool that his students asked for more. Soon, hotels and restaurants wanted them too.

Later, he made toys for Marvel Comics, including a Wolverine figure from X-Men. He also worked for DC Comics. But he loved pumpkins most, so in 2010 he began carving them full-time. He has won Food Network's Outrageous Pumpkins contest two times.

This Halloween, more than 40 of his pumpkin **characters** are on show in Gilbert, Arizona, until November 1, 2026. On October 24, people can watch him **carve** one live.

His tip: pick a big, heavy pumpkin. It does not have to be round. Funny shapes give it **character**!

Word Treasure

sculptures -- Sculptures are pieces of art shaped or carved into 3-D forms.

3-D -- 3-D means having height, width and depth, not flat.

carve -- To carve means to cut into something to make a shape.

character -- Character means special features that make something interesting and different.

Background you need

Carving pumpkins into jack-o'-lanterns is a fun Halloween tradition.

Most people cut simple faces, but some artists carve the thick inside of a pumpkin into detailed 3-D shapes.

Towns sometimes set up pumpkin displays in the fall for families to visit.

Break it down

WHO: Pumpkin artist Ray Villafane
WHAT: He turns pumpkins into spooky 3-D sculptures and is showing more than 40 pumpkin characters
WHERE: Gilbert, Arizona, until November 1, 2026
WHY: He loves carving pumpkins and wants to share his art at Halloween

Why it matters

His story shows that a hobby you love can grow into something amazing.

Test what you remember

1. What does Ray Villafane turn pumpkins into?

- (A) Pies
- (B) 3-D sculptures
- (C) Lanterns only
- (D) Soup

2. What job did he have in Michigan?

- (A) Baker
- (B) Doctor
- (C) Art teacher
- (D) Bus driver

3. Which X-Men figure did he make?

- (A) Batman
- (B) Wolverine
- (C) Spider-Man
- (D) Superman

4. How many times has he won Outrageous Pumpkins?

- (A) Zero
- (B) Two
- (C) Five
- (D) Ten

5. Where is his pumpkin show this year?

- (A) Boston, Massachusetts
- (B) Gilbert, Arizona
- (C) Paris, France
- (D) Tokyo, Japan

6. What kind of pumpkin does he say to pick?

- (A) Green
- (B) Big and heavy
- (C) Tiny and light
- (D) Flat

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: B

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):